YIXING AUDIO GUIDE · PART III

Shanjuan Cave Scenic Area — English Audio Guide

Complete 8-Stop Spoken Tour Script · 1.0s Sentence Pauses & 2.0s Paragraph Pauses · Total Duration: 16m 25s

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STOP 01 · 1:30 · GUZHENG & DIZI INTRO · shanjuan_01_intro.mp3

Welcome & Overview: The Birthplace of Cave Tourism in China

Visitor Center, Pedestrian Village Street, Mr. Chu Nanqiang's 1934 Opening & The Three Great Wonder Caves of the World

Hello everyone! Welcome to the Shanjuan Cave Scenic Area—celebrated as the birthplace of karst cave tourism in China and the legendary setting of the classic Chinese romance, The Butterfly Lovers. It is a real pleasure to be your guide today and share the stories and wonders of Shanjuan Cave with you.

Please follow me this way. Just outside the Visitor Center on our left is the pedestrian village street, where you will find photo studios, convenience shops, a local country-style restaurant, and a cultural gift shop.

Located in Zhangzhu Town, about 23 kilometers southwest of downtown Yixing, the scenic area brings together five highlights: the karst caves, Butterfly Lovers folklore, an ancient Third-Century stele, century-old trees, and leisure gardens. Back in 1921, local visionary Mr. Chu Nanqiang began developing the cave. After thirteen years of tireless work, it officially opened to the public on November 11, 1934—pioneering cave tourism in China. Early on, it was hailed alongside the Caves of Han-sur-Lesse in Belgium and the caves of Lyon in France as one of the "Three Great Wonder Caves of the World." Surrounded by lush hills and clear streams, the cave's natural rock formations are so breathtaking that ancient scholars praised it as a "Sacred Ancient Marvel" and an "Immortal Wonderland on Earth."

STOP 02 · 2:14 · GUZHENG GLISSANDO · shanjuan_02_pailou.mp3

The Grand Archway & The Ancient Names of Yixing

Jun-Glazed Roof Tiles, Fei Xinwo's Left-Handed Calligraphy & How Jingxi and Yangxian Became Yixing

Walking across the plaza, right in front of us stands the grand Shanjuan Cave Archway. Look up at the bright yellow glazed tiles on the roof—they were crafted using Yixing's famous traditional Jun-glazed pottery technique. The three bold characters for "Shanjuan Cave" on the gate were written by the renowned left-handed calligrapher Mr. Fei Xinwo. On both sides of the pillars, you can see a couplet written in 1986 by Mr. Huang Yanghui, a famous painter and calligrapher who studied under Master Xu Beihong. It reads: "Every step in Jingxi is a scenic wonder; every corner of Yangxian holds a hidden grotto heaven."

Both Jingxi and Yangxian are ancient names for Yixing. Over 6,000 years ago, this area faced the sea with hills covered in wild brambles—called jing—and streams flowing down into the valleys, giving rise to the poetic name "Jingxi," or Bramble Stream. Later, in 221 BC, when China's First Emperor Qin Shi Huang unified the country, Jingxi was renamed "Yangxian." During the Jin Dynasty, after local hero Zhou Qi raised an army three times to help the imperial court put down rebellions, the court honored him by renaming the prefecture "Yixing," meaning Righteous Prosperity. Later, during the Song Dynasty, to avoid using a character from the emperor's personal name, the first character was changed to the "Yi" we use today—meaning a place suitable for living and thriving. Finally, in 1988, Yixing became a county-level city.

With over 7,000 years of pottery-making history and more than 2,200 years as an established county, Yixing is proudly known across China as the “Ancient Capital of Pottery, Oasis of Tea, Ocean of Bamboo, and World of Caves.” Historical records list 87 karst caves scattered across Yixing’s southwestern hills, five of which are now open to visitors. Among them, Shanjuan Cave is world-famous for having a cave inside a mountain, a river inside a cave, and boats gliding along that underground river.

STOP 03 · 1:50 · BREEZE & CHIME · shanjuan_03_statue_museum.mp3

Master Shanjuan Statue & Chu Nanqiang Exhibition Hall

The Sage Who Declined Emperor Shun’s Throne, the Ancient “Lei” Spade & The Pioneer of Chinese Cave Tourism

Please follow me through the archway. On our left stands a statue of the ancient sage Master Shanjuan. Legend has it that he lived here as a hermit, which is how Shanjuan Cave got its name. Master Shanjuan was a revered philosopher and the teacher of the legendary Emperors Yao and Shun. According to ancient texts, when Emperor Shun grew old, he saw that Shanjuan had the wisdom and virtue to govern the land, and offered to pass the throne to him. However, Master Shanjuan replied: “I live freely and happily between heaven and earth—why would I ever need the throne?” To avoid Emperor Shun’s repeated offers, he traveled all the way from Hunan Province to these quiet mountains, found this karst cave, and lived here in seclusion. He also taught advanced farming skills to the local villagers. To remember his kindness, locals named the cave where he lived “Shanjuan Cave.”

Notice the wooden tool he is holding in his hand—it is called a lei, an ancient two-pronged spade used in pre-imperial China and the ancestor of the modern plow. Farmers would press the pointed tip into the soil and step on the crossbar to turn the earth.

Just ahead, we arrive at the Chu Nanqiang Exhibition Hall. Born in Yixing in 1876, Mr. Chu Nanqiang was a respected civic leader who single-handedly spearheaded the restoration and development of both Shanjuan Cave and Zhanggong Cave. Remembered as the pioneer of cave tourism in China, his exhibition hall tells the story of his scholarly family, his determination to open the caves, and his lifelong devotion to his hometown. Right ahead is the ticket gate—let’s step inside the main cavern of Shanjuan Cave!

STOP 04 · 2:54 · WATER DROPS & GUZHENG · shanjuan_04_middle_cave.mp3

The Middle Cave: The Lion and Elephant Hall

30,000-Year-Old Pillar of Strength, Green Lion & White Elephant, Purple Clay Guanyin Shrine & “Immortal Wonderland on Earth”

Everyone, welcome inside Shanjuan Cave! Covering roughly 5,000 square meters, the cave is grand and magnificent—like a naturally sculpted stone palace. The entire system spans three levels and four interconnected caverns: the Upper Cave, Middle Cave, Lower Cave, and Water Cave, each brought to life with its own themed light show.

We are now in the Middle Cave. Look up toward the ceiling, where two projected butterflies flutter side by side. Behind them rises a massive seven-meter stalagmite pillar known as the Pillar of Strength, named because it stands like an unshakable rock in a rushing river. Geologists tell us this giant pillar grew drop by drop as minerals in the dripping cave water slowly crystallized over more than 30,000 years! Perched right at the top of the pillar is a natural rock formation resembling the Laughing Buddha—known as the “Welcoming Buddha,” smiling toward the entrance to greet visitors from around the world.

Above us, floating sky lanterns and dancing butterflies make the cavern feel like a fairytale palace. You can even scan the QR code with your phone to write a wish and release your own digital sky lantern onto the cave ceiling! High above, you can also see four large characters meaning the “Lion and Elephant Hall,” inscribed by the noted educator Mr. Lü Fengzi.

Why is it called the Lion and Elephant Hall? Look to both sides of the cavern, where two giant natural rock formations stand guard—one shaped like a Green Lion, and the other like a White Elephant. On the White Elephant, you can clearly make out its long trunk touching the ground, along with its tusks and legs. Across from it, the Lion tilts its head slightly with its long tail trailing to the floor. Feel free to step onto the interactive pads in front of them to awaken these ancient stone guardians!

Right beside the White Elephant sits a lifelike statue of Guanyin, the Bodhisattva of Compassion, invited here from Mount Putuo. Nestled behind her are eight smaller Guanyin statues handcrafted from local Yixing purple clay, arranged like a traditional Buddhist island shrine.

As we walk forward toward the pool on our left, look up at the rock wall: the light projection recreates scenes from the Butterfly Lovers, Liang Shanbo and Zhu Yingtai, studying side by side and transforming into two butterflies dancing together. This is a wonderful spot to pause for photos. Now look straight ahead at the four large seal-script characters carved into the rock face. Bestowed upon Shanjuan Cave 1,500 years ago by the famous Taoist scholar Tao Hongjing, they mean “An Immortal Wonderland on Earth.”

STOP 05 · 2:27 · BAMBOO FLUTE MELODY · shanjuan_05_upper_cave.mp3

The Upper Cave: The Cloud and Mist Hall

Year-Round 23°C Eternal Spring, Auspicious Stone Bats, 1986 Journey to the West Filming Site & Ancient Origin Pool

Let’s head up the stairs on the left toward the Upper Cave. Notice how the huge rock formation above acts like a natural curtain, blocking air circulation between the Middle Cave and the Upper Cave. Because of this, the Upper Cave stays at a comfortable temperature of around 23 degrees Celsius all year round—warm in winter and cool in summer, like eternal spring! In winter, the temperature difference between the inside and outside fills the cavern with swirling white mist, which is why the Upper Cave is called the “Cloud and Mist Hall.”

Straight ahead of us is a romantic light installation of butterflies dancing around two intertwined ancient trees—a classic Chinese symbol of eternal love. You can step onto the interactive platform here to experience this fairytale scene up close.

On our left is a natural rock landscape that looks just like a traditional southern Chinese water town, complete with a stone willow tree by the pond. Look up above it, and you’ll spot a giant stone bat spreading its wings as if flying toward us, with a smaller bat following right behind. In Chinese culture, the word for bat (fu) sounds identical to the word for good fortune, so spotting bats here means “blessings arriving from all directions!”

Next to it, clusters of stalactites hang down like budding lotus flowers reflected in the crystal-clear water below—creating a magical illusion of flowers in the water and the moon in a mirror. Fun fact: the Upper Cave’s dramatic rock formations were so vivid that Episode 8 of the classic 1986 television series Journey to the West was filmed right here!

Look just above our heads at that translucent stalactite with tiny water droplets hanging from its tip. As each drop slowly deposits a microscopic ring of minerals, the stalactite grows millimeter by millimeter over thousands of years. To our right stands a pair of stone columns that grew together over tens of thousands of years, symbolizing love that never parts. And right beside us is the Ancient Origin Pool. See that small natural spring opening on the rock wall? Millions of years ago, ancient seawater broke through a tiny fissure right here and slowly hollowed out this vast cavern—so the Upper Cave actually began forming from this very spot!

STOP 06 · 1:32 · CLASSICAL GUZHENG · shanjuan_06_baibing_xiaochu.mp3

The “May All Illnesses Vanish” Inscription

The Touching Friendship of Industrialist Rong Desheng & Developer Chu Nanqiang, Re-inscribed by Rong Yiren

At the entrance to the stairway leading down, look at the four bold characters carved into the rock wall. They mean “May All Illnesses Vanish,” and they were re-inscribed in October 1986 by Mr. Rong Yiren, the former Vice President of China.

There is a touching story behind them. The original calligraphy was written by Rong Yiren’s father, Mr. Rong Desheng, a famous industrialist from nearby Wuxi. Mr. Rong and cave developer Mr. Chu Nanqiang were close friends. When Mr. Rong learned that Chu Nanqiang had exhausted his entire family fortune to restore Shanjuan Cave—even selling off his wife’s jewelry and his daughter-in-law’s dowry—he was deeply moved and generously donated all the cement and steel needed to finish the project.

When Shanjuan Cave officially opened on November 11, 1934, Chu Nanqiang invited Mr. Rong to visit. Although Mr. Rong was feeling slightly unwell that day, he came anyway. After exploring the upper and lower caves, he was so captivated by the scenery and felt so uplifted that his discomfort completely disappeared! Inspired, he picked up a brush and wrote “May All Illnesses Vanish.” After the original carving was lost in the 1960s, his son Rong Yiren re-inscribed it here in 1986. Standing here today, I also wish all of you abundant health, happiness, and joy!

STOP 07 · 1:50 · WATERFALL & CHIME · shanjuan_07_lower_cave_waterfall.mp3

The Lower Cave & The Underground Waterfall

The 10-Year Hand-Chiseled 105-Step Tunnel, Nine-Tiered Pools & Cliffside Underground Waterfall

Ahead of us is the 105-step staircase, descending five stories deep into the Lower Cave. Originally, the Middle Cave and Lower Cave were not connected at all—visitors had to walk outside and go around the mountain. Starting in 1925, twenty stonemasons worked here every single day to chisel a tunnel through the solid rock. Because explosives would have damaged the delicate cave structure, they couldn’t use dynamite. Instead, they used an ingenious sound-locating method—striking gongs and listening to the echo through the rock while chiseling from both ends at the same time. It took a full ten years of hand-chiseling to carve out this shortcut!

On rainy days, as you spiral down these stairs, every turn echoes with a different natural sound from the rushing water outside—first like roaring wind and thunder, then like surging ocean waves, then like beating war drums, and finally like ten thousand galloping horses.

Stepping into the Lower Cave, you can see a figure seated in meditation beneath a towering stone pine—that is Master Shanjuan, the ancient sage who discovered our cave. Moving forward, on our right are the Nine-Tiered Pools, formed naturally by dripping water and shaped just like terraced rice fields in southern China. On our left, sheets of hanging stalactites drape across the cave opening like a natural stone curtain.

Right beyond this curtain lies the signature spectacle of Shanjuan Cave: a dramatic cliffside waterfall plunging straight into the underground cavern! When developer Chu Nanqiang stood here, he wrote a famous poem comparing the waterfall to the Milky Way pouring down from heaven into the heart of the mountain, roaring like underground thunder.

STOP 08 · 1:51 · CRYSTAL RIVER & FINALE · shanjuan_08_water_cave_closing.mp3

The Water Cave (Crystal Palace) Boat Ride & Finale

120-Meter Underground River Boat Ride Through Three Bends, the Water Gate & Gliding Out the Dragon Gate

Walking back from the waterfall, we arrive at our final highlight—the Water Cave, also known as the Crystal Palace. Please watch your step as we board the boat!

The Water Cave is an ancient underground river stretching 120 meters long, winding through three gentle bends. Right ahead is the Water Gate, where the rock ceiling dips to its lowest point. As our boat glides forward, dreamy butterfly lights dance across the vaulted ceiling like floating clouds and starry reflections on the water—making you feel as if you are rowing through the Milky Way itself.

Look closely at the walls of the Water Cave, and you'll notice countless smaller grottos, all interconnected. Every single one was carved by underground water dissolving the limestone over millions of years. In fact, a karst cave is never truly finished—it is still changing and evolving every single moment. With its winding river bends, sheer rock cliffs, low overhanging ceiling, and fantastical stone shapes, riding through here feels just like traveling through a tunnel in time.

As the famous Chinese poem goes: "Where hills and streams seem to end and no path remains, beyond shady willows and bright flowers another village appears!" As our boat rounds the third and final bend and glides out through the Dragon Gate, daylight suddenly opens up before us—bringing our underground journey to a wonderful close. Ladies and gentlemen, please stay seated until the boat comes to a complete stop, and then step off carefully and follow the path out of the cave. Thank you all for exploring Shanjuan Cave with me today, and enjoy the rest of your trip in Yixing!